

Understanding the IELTS Speaking Band Descriptors

The examiners use a *criteria sheet* called the **Band Descriptors** to evaluate IELTS speaking. There is a publicly available version, and you can see it below.

IELTS™

SPEAKING: Band Descriptors (public version)

Band	Fluency and coherence	Lexical resource	Grammatical range and accuracy	Pronunciation
9	• speaks fluently with only rare repetition or self-correction; • any hesitation is content-related rather than to find words or grammar • speaks coherently with fully appropriate cohesive features • develops topics fully and appropriately	• uses vocabulary with full flexibility and precision in all topics • uses idiomatic language naturally and accurately	• uses a full range of structures naturally and appropriately • produces consistently accurate structures apart from 'slips' characteristic of native speaker speech	• uses a full range of pronunciation features with precision and subtlety • sustains flexible use of features throughout • is effortless to understand
8	• speaks fluently with only occasional repetition or self-correction; hesitation is usually content-related and only rarely to search for language • develops topics coherently and appropriately	• uses a wide vocabulary resource readily and flexibly to convey precise meaning • uses less common and idiomatic vocabulary skillfully, with occasional inaccuracies • uses paraphrase effectively as required	• uses a wide range of structures flexibly • produces a majority of error-free sentences with only very occasional inappropriacies or basic/non-systematic errors	• uses a wide range of pronunciation features • sustains flexible use of features, with only occasional lapses • is easy to understand throughout; L1 accent has minimal effect on intelligibility
7	• speaks at length without noticeable effort or loss of coherence • may demonstrate language-related hesitation at times, or some repetition and/or self-correction • uses a range of connectives and discourse markers with some flexibility	• uses vocabulary resource flexibly to discuss a variety of topics • uses some less common and idiomatic vocabulary and shows some awareness of style and collocation, with some inappropriate choices • uses paraphrase effectively	• uses a range of complex structures with some flexibility • frequently produces error-free sentences, though some grammatical mistakes persist	• shows all the positive features of Band 6 and some, but not all, of the positive features of Band 8
6	• is willing to speak at length, though may lose coherence at times due to occasional repetition, self-correction or hesitation • uses a range of connectives and discourse markers but not always appropriately	• has a wide enough vocabulary to discuss topics at length and make meaning clear in spite of inappropriacies • generally paraphrases successfully	• uses a mix of simple and complex structures, but with limited flexibility • may make frequent mistakes with complex structures though these rarely cause comprehension problems	• uses a range of pronunciation features with mixed control • shows some effective use of features but this is not sustained • can generally be understood throughout, though mispronunciation of individual words or sounds reduces clarity at times
5	• usually maintains flow of speech but uses repetition, self-correction and/or slow speech to keep going • may over-use certain connectives and discourse markers • produces simple speech fluently, but more complex communication causes fluency problems	• manages to talk about familiar and unfamiliar topics but uses vocabulary with limited flexibility • attempts to use paraphrase but with mixed success	• produces basic sentence forms with reasonable accuracy • uses a limited range of more complex structures, but these usually contain errors and may cause some comprehension problems	• shows all the positive features of Band 4 and some, but not all, of the positive features of Band 6
4	• cannot respond without noticeable pauses and may speak slowly, with frequent repetition and self-correction • links basic sentences but with repetitious use of simple connectives and some breakdowns in coherence	• is able to talk about familiar topics but can only convey basic meaning on unfamiliar topics and makes frequent errors in word choice • rarely attempts paraphrase	• produces basic sentence forms and some correct simple sentences but subordinate structures are rare • errors are frequent and may lead to misunderstanding	• uses a limited range of pronunciation features • attempts to control features but lapses are frequent • mispronunciations are frequent and cause some difficulty for the listener
3	• speaks with long pauses • has limited ability to link simple sentences • gives only simple responses and is frequently unable to convey basic message	• uses simple vocabulary to convey personal information • has insufficient vocabulary for less familiar topics	• attempts basic sentence forms but with limited success, or relies on apparently memorised utterances • makes numerous errors except in memorised expressions	• shows some of the features of Band 2 and some, but not all, of the positive features of Band 4
2	• pauses lengthily before most words • little communication possible	• only produces isolated words or memorised utterances	• cannot produce basic sentence forms	• Speech is often unintelligible
1	• no communication possible • no rateable language			
0	• does not attend			

The IELTS speaking band descriptors are a bit technical, but here they are in **simple English**. You are evaluated in **4 areas** as you can see below. For each area, the band descriptors tell you what **aspect** of that area you need to focus on.

FLUENCY

1. Effort or Ease of speaking
2. Hesitations
3. Use of connectives and discourse markers
4. Ability to develop a topic

VOCABULARY

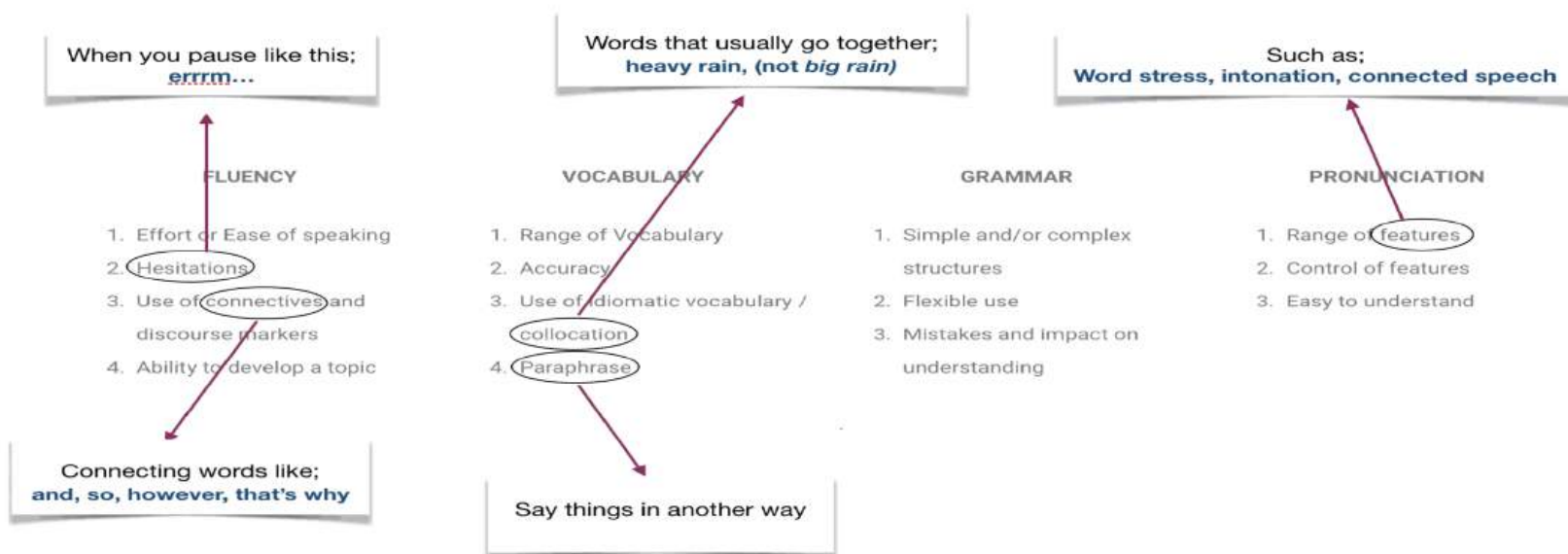
1. Range of Vocabulary
2. Accuracy
3. Use of idiomatic vocabulary / collocation
4. Paraphrase

GRAMMAR

1. Simple and/or complex structures
2. Flexible use
3. Mistakes and impact on understanding

PRONUNCIATION

1. Range of features
2. Control of features
3. Easy to understand



Topics for Part 1

Work

What is your job?
Where do you work?
Why did you choose that job?
Is it a popular job in your country?
Do you like your job?
Do you get on well with your colleagues? What was your first day like?
What responsibilities do you have at work?
If you had the chance, would you change your job?
Do you plan to continue with your job in the future?

Study

What do you study?
Where do you study that?
Why did you choose that subject?
Is it a popular subject in your country?
Do you like that subject?
Do you get on with your colleagues?
What was your first day like?
What are the main aspects of your subject?
If you had the chance, would you change subject?
Do you plan to get a job in the same field as your subject?

Hometown

Where is your hometown?
Do you like your hometown?
Do you often visit your hometown?
What is your hometown like?
What is the oldest place in your hometown?
What is there for a foreigner to do or see in your hometown?
How could your hometown be improved?
Has your hometown changed much since you were a child?
Is there good public transportation in your hometown?
Do you think your hometown is a good place to bring up children?

Home

Where is your home?
Do you live in a house or a flat?
Who do you live with?
Are there many rooms in your home?
What is your favourite room?
How are the walls decorated?
What would you change about your home?
Do you plan to live there in the future?
What facilities are there near your home?
What is your neighbourhood like?
Do most people live in houses in your country?

Common Topics in Part 1

Art

Are you good at art?
Did you learn art at school when you were a child?
What kind of art do you like?
Is art popular in your country?
Have you ever been to an art gallery?
Do you think children can benefit from going to art galleries?

Birthdays

Do you enjoy your birthdays?
Do you usually celebrate your birthday?
What did you do on your last birthday?
Can you remember a birthday you enjoyed as a child?
Do most people celebrate their birthdays with a party in your country?
Which birthdays are considered important in your country?

Clothes

Are clothes important to you?
What kind of clothes do you usually wear?
Do you ever wear the traditional clothes of your country?
Where do you usually buy your clothes?
Have you ever worn a uniform?
Do most people in your country follow fashion?

Daily Routine

When do you usually get up in the morning?

Do you usually have the same routine every day?

What is your daily routine?

Do you ever change your routine?

Is your routine the same today as it was when you were a child?

Do you think it is important to have a daily routine?

Dictionaries

Do you often use a dictionary?

What do you use dictionaries for?

What kinds of dictionaries do you think are most useful?

Do you think dictionaries are useful for learning a language?

What kind of information can you find in a dictionary?

Evenings

What do you often do in the evenings?

Do you do the same thing every evening?

Do you prefer to spend your evenings with family or friends?

Do you ever work or study in the evenings?

What is a popular activity for young people in your country in the evenings?

Do you do the same thing in the evenings as you did when you were a child?

Family & Friends

Do you spend much time with your family?

Who are you closest to in your family?

Do you prefer spending time with your family or friends?

Who is your best friend?

Are you still friends with people from your childhood?

Is family important in your country?

Food

What's your favourite food?

Have you always liked the same food?

Is there any food you dislike?
What is a common meal in your country?
Do you have a healthy diet?
What do you think of fast food?

Hobbies

Do you have a hobby?
What equipment do you need for it?
Do you think hobbies should be shared with other people?
Did you have a hobby as a child?
What hobbies are popular in your country?
Why do you think people have hobbies?

Internet

How often do you go online?
What do you use the internet for?
How do you get online?
Do you have your own computer?
What's your favourite website?
Do you think children should be allowed unsupervised access to the internet?

Leisure Time

What is your favourite leisure activity?
What did you enjoy doing in your free time as a child?
Do you prefer to spend your free time with other people or alone? What is a common leisure activity in your country?
Do most people in your country get two days off a week?
Do you think leisure time is important?

Music

Do you like music?
What's your favourite type of music?
Can you sing?
Did you learn music at school?
If you could learn a musical instrument, what would it be?
Do you think music is important?

Neighbours & Neighbourhood

Do you like your neighbours?

Are neighbours usually close to each other in your country?

What is your neighbourhood like?

Do you think your neighbourhood is a good place for children?

How could your neighbourhood be improved?

Do you think it is important to have a good relationship with your neighbours?

Newspapers

How do you usually get your news?

Do you often read the newspapers?

What kind of news do you usually follow?

How do most people get the news in your country?

Do you think international news is important?

Pets

Do you have a pet?

Do you like animals?

What's your favourite animal?

What is a popular pet to have in your country?

Did you have a pet as a child?

Why do people have pets?

Reading

Do you often read books or magazines?

What is your favourite kind of book to read?

Do you often read newspapers?

Do you have any e-books?

What books did you read as a child?

Do you think it is important to encourage children to read?

Shopping

Do you like shopping?

What's your favourite shop?

Do you prefer shopping alone or with others?

Speaking part 1 six common
question

What you will learn

- How Part 1 works
- How to improve your answers

You can finish the course in 1 day

The secret is in the practice!

The Speaking Success System

3 simple steps to becoming a confident speaker of English

1. **Discover** new language in the model answers
2. **Practise** repeating with me and making your own phrases
3. **Review** with the quiz

Course Contents

1. What Happens in Part 1
2. Six Common Question Types
3. What the examiner looks for
4. Answers

What happens

- Examiner gives **their** name
- Examiner asks **your** name
- They check your ID
- **Records** the exam (*audio*)
- They **may** write things down

What happens

They will ask about

- Your **study or work**

OR

- Your **home**

OR

- Your **hometown**

What happens

They will ask about

- 3 or 4 **questions** on 2 **Topics**

Give short answers

2 - 4 sentences / 10 – 15 seconds

6 Common Question Types

1. Do you (verb?)
2. Are you good at it?
3. Is (noun) popular?
4. Did you (verb) as a child?
5. Do you prefer A or B?
6. What kinds of (noun) do you (verb)?

Common Question Types

Do you (verb)?

Are you good at it?

Is (noun) popular
in your country?

Did you (verb) as a child?

Do you prefer A or B?

What kinds of ...do you...?

What is Being Tested

*Can you use tenses related to the **present** ?*

*Can you describe **ability**?*

*Can you talk about **popularity**?*

*Can you use tenses to talk about the **past**?*

*Can you make **comparisons**?*

*Can you use a **wide range** of vocabulary?*

6 Common Question Types

1. **Do you (verb)?**
2. **Are you good at it?**
3. **Is (noun) popular in your country?**
4. **Did you (verb) as a child?**
5. **Do you prefer A or B?**
6. **What kind of (noun) do you (verb)?**

Do you **cook**?

Yes, I do cook.
I cook on a fairly regular basis

I cook

on a regular basis

every now and again

from time to time

once in a blue moon

I've been cooking **since** I was a child



I've been cooking since

I was a kid

I was at school

I was young

I've been cooking for 2 years

I've been cooking for

5 years

ages

as long as I can
remember

I love it!



adore it

am really into it

hate it

am not a big fan

Similar Questions

Do you cook?

Do you wear a watch?

Do you like eating fish?

Do you often write with a pen?

Do you take photos?

Do you go to bed late?

Do you like travelling?

Do you like going to museums?

6 Common Question Types

1. Do you (verb)?
2. **Are you good at it?**
3. Is (noun) popular in your country?
4. Did you (verb) as a child?
5. Do you prefer A or B?
6. What kind of (noun) do you (verb)?

Are you good at it?

Yes, I am good at it



am a dab hand at it
= I am very good at it

have a knack for doing...
= I am quite skilful

can hold my own
= I am good enough

Do you **cook**?

No, I am pretty bad at it



I am

hopeless at it

terrible at it

It's not my forte = not a strength

Similar Questions

Are you good at cooking?

Are you good at singing?

Are you good at getting up early?

Are you good at taking photos?

Are you good at doing puzzles?

Are you good at art?

6 Common Question Types

1. Do you (verb)?
2. Are you good at it?
3. **Is (noun) popular in your country?**
4. Did you (verb) as a child?
5. Do you prefer A or B?
6. What kind of (noun) do you (verb)?

Is **baking** popular in your country?

Yes, it is

It's

well-liked

pretty / fairly / quite trendy

all the rage

Is **baking** popular in your country?

No, not really.

Most people

are not into it

are not big fans

*don't care much
about it*

Similar Questions

Is **cooking** popular in your country?

Are **international celebrities** popular in your country?

Which **colours** are popular in your country?

What kind of **movies** are popular in our country?

Which **sports** are popular in your country?

Why is **chocolate** popular in so many countries?

6 Common Question Types

1. Do you (verb)?
2. Are you good at it?
3. Is (noun) popular in your country?
4. **Did you (verb) as a child?**
5. Do you prefer A or B?
6. What kind of (noun) do you (verb)?

Did you **cook** as a child?

Yes, I did.



I

cooked a lot

used to cook a lot

would cook most days

Did you **cook** as a child?

No, I didn't, to be honest.



I

wasn't into cooking that much
= I didn't like it

wasn't really bothered about it
= didn't care about it

never learnt to cook

Similar Questions

Did you take **art classes** at school?

Did you enjoy **taking history classes** at school?

Did you have **science classes** at school?

Were you **patient** when you were young?

Did you have **the same voice** as a child?

Did you **grow any plants** when you were young?

6 Common Question Types

1. Do you (verb)?
2. Are you good at it?
3. Is (noun) popular in your country?
4. Did you (verb) as a child?
5. **Do you prefer A or B?**
6. What kind of (noun) do you (verb)?

Short Adjectives

Adj. - Comparison

Big – Bigger

Fast – Faster

Quick – Quicker

Long Adjectives

Adj. - *Comparison*

Expensive

more

expensive

—

more

convenient

Interesting

—

more

interesting

—

Do you prefer to travel by train or plane?

I prefer planes because,

They're

much faster/better/cheaper
than trains

far faster/better/cheaper
than trains

way faster/better/cheaper
than trains

Do you prefer to travel by train or plane?

I prefer planes because,

They're

much more convenient/useful/
interesting than trains

far more convenient/useful/
interesting than trains

way more convenient/useful/
interesting than trains

Similar Questions

Do you prefer to live in a flat or a house?

Do you prefer to use a pen or a pencil for writing?

Do you prefer to take photos yourself
or have other people take photos?

Are you more tidy at work or at home? Do
you like dark colours or light colours?

6 Common Question Types

1. Do you (verb)?
2. Are you good at it?
3. Is (noun) popular in your country?
4. Did you (verb) as a child?
5. Do you prefer A or B?
6. **What kind of (noun) do you (verb)?**

What kinds of movies do you like?

It depends on my mood really,

Sometimes

I will go for comedies /
action movies / thrillers

I enjoy comedies / action
movies / thrillers

I am in the mood for
comedies / thrillers

Similar Questions

What kind of **music** do you like?

What kinds of **cakes** do you like?

What kinds of **films** do you like?

What kinds of **cities** do you like to visit?

What kinds of **sports** do you like doing?

Tips to Improve from Band 5.5 to Band 6

1. Give Longer Answers

- Avoid very short or one-word replies.
- Add a reason, example, or explanation after your main idea.
- Example: Instead of “Yes, I like music,” say “Yes, I like music because it helps me relax after a busy day.”

2. Use Simple Linkers to Connect Ideas

- Use words like because, and, but, so, also to join your sentences.
- This shows the examiner you can speak with some coherence.
- Example: “I like reading because it is interesting, and it helps me learn new things.”

3. Practice Common Topics

- Prepare answers for frequent Part 1 topics like: hobbies, family, work/study, daily routine, hometown, food, weather.
- Having some ready ideas reduces hesitation.

4. Work on Pronunciation

- Make sure your words are clear and understandable.
- Practice the stress and intonation patterns of English sentences.
- Even if your grammar isn't perfect, clear pronunciation helps a lot.

5. Use Basic but Correct Grammar

- Focus on using simple past, present, and future tenses correctly.
- Avoid complex sentences if you're not confident; simple sentences spoken accurately are better.
- Example: “Yesterday, I went to the park. It was fun.”

6. Avoid Long Pauses and Fillers

- Practice speaking about familiar topics to reduce pauses like “um,” “ah,” or repeated words.
- Speaking smoothly (even if not perfectly) improves fluency.

7. Use Some Vocabulary Variation

- Learn synonyms for common words:
 - Good → nice, great, enjoyable
 - Like → enjoy, love, prefer
 - Big → large, huge, massive
- This shows range even with simple words.

8. Be Natural and Confident

- Smile and speak clearly.
- It's okay to make small mistakes as long as you keep going.
- Confidence can improve your overall impression.

Example: Improving a 5.5 Answer to Band 6

Band 5.5 Answer

Band 6 Answer

Q: Do you like sports?

A: Yes, I like football.

Q: Do you like sports?

A: Yes, I like football because it is fun to watch and play. I play with my friends on weekends.

1 From Band 6 → 6.5

At Band 6, you usually have:

- Reasonably clear speech but frequent pauses for ideas or grammar.
- Short, simple answers.
- Basic vocabulary with repetition.

Boosters:

1. Extend your answers to 2–3 sentences — avoid one-word or short responses.
2. Add a mini reason or example after your main point.
3. Replace very basic words with slightly better ones (e.g., “good” → “enjoyable,” “bad” → “unpleasant”).
4. Avoid long pauses — use fillers like “Well, to be honest...” or “I'd say...” instead of silence.

Example

Q: *Do you enjoy reading?*

Band 6 answer:

“Yes, I like reading books.”

Band 6.5 answer:

“Yes, I enjoy reading, especially novels. They help me relax after a busy day, and I feel they broaden my imagination.”

2 From Band 6.5 → 7

At Band 6.5, you already:

- Give developed answers but sometimes lack fluency or lexical variety.
- Have some noticeable grammar slips.
- Use a mix of basic and less common vocabulary.

Boosters:

1. Use a wider range of linking phrases — not only “because” or “so,” but also “*which means that...*,” “*as a result...*,” “*what I mean is...*”
2. Insert some less common vocabulary naturally (“*rejuvenating*,” “*captivating*,” “*tedious*”).
3. Vary your grammar structures — mix simple and complex sentences.
4. Sound more natural with idiomatic language (light idioms or phrasal verbs are fine, but not too heavy).
5. Show flexibility with tense — talk about past experiences and future plans when appropriate.

Booster Table

Question	Band 6 (Short/basic)	Band 6.5 (More detail + simple linkers)	Band 7 (Extended, fluent, varied linkers + vocab)
1. Do you work or IELTS Speaking Part 1 – Score study?	“I study at university.”	“I study at university because I want to become a teacher.”	“I’m currently studying mathematics at university, and also I’m doing some part-time tutoring, which means that I get to apply what I learn in real life.”
2. What’s your favorite hobby?	“I like reading.”	“I enjoy reading because it’s relaxing.”	“I absolutely enjoy reading, especially historical novels, as they transport me to different eras and broaden my knowledge.”
3. Do you enjoy traveling?	“Yes, I like traveling.”	“Yes, I enjoy traveling, for example , I went to Dhaka last month.”	“Definitely, traveling is something I love, not only because it’s exciting but also because it gives me a fresh perspective on life. For instance , my trip to Dhaka introduced me to so many cultural traditions I hadn’t seen before.”
4. What kind of music do you like?	“I like pop music.”	“I like pop music because it’s lively.”	“I’m into pop music, and sometimes I listen to soft rock as well . The main reason is that the rhythm energizes me, and also the lyrics are often uplifting.”
5. Do you prefer mornings or evenings?	“I like evenings.”	“I prefer evenings because they’re quieter.”	“I’d say evenings, mainly because the atmosphere is calm and also I can unwind after a busy day. What I mean is , I feel more productive at night than in the morning.”
6. Do you often watch TV?	“Yes, I watch TV.”	“Yes, I watch TV every day after dinner.”	“Yes, I watch TV quite often, especially documentaries and travel shows. For instance , last night I watched a program about life in the Arctic, and it was fascinating.”
7. What’s your favorite season?	“I like winter.”	“I like winter because it’s cool.”	“Winter is my favorite season, mainly because the weather is pleasant here in Sylhet and I can enjoy warm clothes. On top of that , it’s the perfect time for family gatherings.”
8. Do you usually have breakfast?	“Yes, I eat breakfast.”	“Yes, I usually eat breakfast because it gives me energy.”	“I never skip breakfast, as it sets me up for the day. For example , I usually have paratha and tea, which keep me full until lunchtime.”
9. Do you prefer the city or the countryside?	“I like the city.”	“I prefer the city because there are more jobs.”	“I’d go for the city, not only because there are more job opportunities but also because it’s more vibrant. However , I sometimes miss the peaceful atmosphere of the countryside.”
	“Yes, I like football.”	“Yes, I like football because it’s exciting.”	“Yes, football is my favorite sport, and I play it with friends every weekend. The thing is , it keeps me active and also teaches teamwork.”

LINKERS FOR PART 1

1 Starting Your Answer Naturally

Well...

Q: *Do you like cooking?*

A: "**Well**, I don't cook every day, but sometimes I make pasta or soup."

Actually...

Q: *Do you enjoy reading?*

A: "**Actually**, I read only sometimes, maybe when I'm free at night."

To be honest...

Q: *Do you get up early?*

A: "**To be honest**, I'm not good at waking up early, but I have to for work."

Honestly speaking...

Q: *Do you like your city?*

A: "**Honestly speaking**, it's nice, but it's too crowded for me."

If I'm honest...

Q: *Do you like sports?*

A: "**If I'm honest**, I don't play many sports, but I watch football."

I'd say...

Q: *What's your favourite season?*

A: "**I'd say** summer, because I can go to the beach."

Hmm, let me think...

Q: *Do you enjoy travelling?*

A: "**Hmm, let me think...** yes, I like going to new cities."

You know...

Q: *Do you use public transport?*

A: "**You know**, yes, because it's cheap."

In my opinion...

Q: *Is it better to live alone or with family?*

A: "**In my opinion**, living with family is better because it's not lonely."

2 Adding More Information

and also...

Q: *Do you like shopping?*

A: "I like buying clothes, **and also** shoes."

as well...

Q: *Do you enjoy music?*

A: "Yes, I like pop music, and jazz **as well**."

plus...

Q: *Do you like your hometown?*

A: "Yes, it's quiet, **plus** there are nice parks."

on top of that...

Q: *Do you like summer?*

A: "Yes, it's sunny, **on top of that**, I can go swimming."

what's more...

Q: *Do you like your job?*

A: "Yes, it's good, **what's more**, the people are friendly."

not only that but...

Q: *Do you enjoy studying English?*

A: "Yes, it's fun, **not only that but** it helps me with my job."

as well as that...

Q: *Do you often eat out?*

A: "Yes, I do. **As well as that**, I sometimes order takeaway."

3 Giving Reasons

because...

Q: *Do you like your neighbourhood?*

A: "Yes, **because** it's clean."

as...

Q: *Do you prefer coffee or tea?*

A: "Tea, **as** it's lighter."

since...

Q: *Do you like learning languages?*

A: "Yes, **since** it's useful."

the main reason is that...

Q: *Do you often go jogging?*

A: "Yes, **the main reason is that** it's healthy."

mainly because...

Q: *Do you enjoy winter?*

A: "No, not really, **mainly because** it's too cold."

which means that...

Q: *Do you like living near the sea?*

A: "Yes, **which means that** I can visit the beach."

and that's why...

Q: *Do you take public transport?*

A: "Yes, it's cheaper, **and that's why** I use it."

4 Explaining or Clarifying

what I mean is...

Q: *Do you like reading?*

A: "Yes, but only stories. **What I mean is**, not textbooks."

in other words...

Q: *Do you enjoy cooking?*

A: "I do, **in other words**, I like making food at home."

basically...

Q: *Do you like sports?*

A: "**Basically**, I like football and basketball."

to put it simply...

Q: *Do you like your job?*

A: "Yes, **to put it simply**, it's good."

the point is...

Q: *Do you like living alone?*

A: "Sometimes, yes. **The point is**, I like my own space."

5 Giving Examples

for example...

Q: *What do you like to do on weekends?*

A: "I like to go for a walk, **for example**, in the park."

for instance...

Q: *Do you enjoy sports?*

A: "Yes, **for instance**, I play badminton."

such as...

Q: *What do you usually eat for breakfast?*

A: "I have fruit, **such as** bananas."

like...

Q: *Do you enjoy watching films?*

A: "Yes, comedies **like** Mr Bean."

to give you an idea...

Q: *Do you read a lot?*

A: "Yes, **to give you an idea**, I read two books a month."

6 Showing Contrast

but...

Q: *Do you like city life?*

A: "Yes, **but** it's noisy."

however...

Q: *Do you like working from home?*

A: "Yes, **however**, I miss my friends."

on the other hand...

Q: *Do you prefer summer or winter?*

A: "Summer is nice, **on the other hand**, winter is cosy."

although...

Q: *Do you like shopping?*

A: "Yes, **although** it's tiring."

even though...

Q: *Do you enjoy your job?*

A: "Yes, **even though** it's busy."

whereas...

Q: *Do you prefer coffee or tea?*

A: "Coffee in the morning, **whereas** tea at night."

7 Sequencing Ideas

first of all...

Q: *How do you prepare for an exam?*

A: "**First of all**, I read my notes."

to start with...

Q: *How do you plan a trip?*

A: "**To start with**, I choose where to go."

then...

Q: *What's your morning routine?*

A: "I wake up, **then** I eat breakfast."

after that...

Q: *How do you usually spend Sunday?*

A: "I clean my room, **after that**, I watch TV."

finally...

Q: *How do you cook your favourite dish?*

A: "I cut the vegetables, **finally**, I cook them."

PPF Strategy – Speaking Part 2

Teacher's notes

Aim: Use PPF (past, present, future) strategy to help Ss speak at length (Assessment Criteria – *Fluency and Coherence*) and demonstrate knowledge of a range of more complex grammar structures (Assessment Criteria – *Grammatical Range and Accuracy*).

Instructions

1. Write the following on the board.

**What was the most memorable trip you've ever taken?
When did you go?
Where did you go?
What did you do?
Why was it memorable?**

Put Ss in pairs. They should answer the questions above. As this is only a warmer, give them 5 mins to talk and tell them they can ask their partner questions if they want.

2. Get brief feedback from 1 or 2 Ss about where they went. Ask the class how easy / difficult they found it to talk about the topic. Elicit what happens in Part 2 of the Speaking test (= **talk for 1-2 mins about a topic from a topic card, 1 min to prepare**).

Tell Ss they'll look at a strategy to help them talk for longer in Part 2 of the Speaking test.

Hand out worksheet. Ss read the task card / extracts and try to guess what PPF stands for (**Past, Present, Future**). If they find it difficult, point out the underlined verbs. Get them to write Past, Present, Future on the left of the worksheet.

3. Ss make notes on the worksheet about what they could say about the past, present and future related to their most memorable trip. Ss pair up and roleplay examiner and candidate. 'Candidate' uses their notes to help them talk for 2 mins about the task card. Ss change roles. The 'examiner' can give feedback about range and accuracy of grammar.

Notes:

- It is not essential that they talk about past, present and future in Speaking Part 2. This strategy is an aid to help Ss develop their answer. It is also likely to help them demonstrate knowledge of a wider range of structures.
- It might not be natural, for example, to stick to future tenses only when talking about the future (see the 'future' extract on the worksheet – the speaker uses present perfect). Again, this doesn't matter. The important thing is to try to develop their answer.

Alternative suggestion

PPF strategy can be used with any Speaking Part 2 task.

You could also give Ss a list of 'first lines' from task cards (e.g. *Describe an important building in your country*, *Describe a film you have learnt something from*, etc) and ask them to give PP and F sentences for each.

Worksheet – PPF Strategy – Speaking Part 2

You can use the PPF strategy to help you think of more things to say in Part 2 of the Speaking test.

Look at the task card below and some extracts from how a candidate answered the question. **What do you think PPF stands for?**

Describe a memorable trip you took.

You should say:

when you took the trip

where you went

what you did

and explain why this trip was memorable for you.

P _____ “It was definitely far more exciting than any holiday I’d been on before. I’d only been to Europe so Asia was a completely different experience for me...”

P _____ “I’ve got some photos from the trip on my computer. They come up as screensavers after my computer hasn’t been used for a while, so I look at them and start dreaming about going back there...”

F _____ “Actually, I’m planning to take my girlfriend there next year but we’re going to stay at a beach resort this time because I’ve heard there are some lovely places by the sea. We’ll probably just take day trips to cities and temples. I can’t wait!...”

Now think about your most memorable trip and make some notes about what you could say for each category below.

P _____
.....
.....

P _____
.....
.....

F _____
.....
.....

IELTS Speaking Part 2: Band Progression

Topic: *Describe a memorable holiday you had*

Band 5.5

Tips:

- Give very basic answers with short sentences
- Use mostly simple grammar and vocabulary
- Some hesitation and repetition
- Limited details and explanations

Sample:

"Last year, I go to the beach. It was good. I swim and eat food. I happy."

Band 6

Tips:

- Give longer answers with simple explanations
- Use simple linkers (first, then, because)
- Use some past tense forms correctly
- Add feelings or opinions simply

Sample:

"Last year, I went to the beach for a holiday. **First**, I spent a lot of time swimming in the sea. **Then**, I tried different local foods, which were delicious. **I was very happy** because I relaxed and enjoyed my time with family."

Band 6.5

Tips:

- Use more varied grammar (past continuous, simple perfect)
- Use a wider range of linkers (after that, finally, also)
- Add more description and explain feelings more clearly
- Avoid frequent hesitations or pauses

Sample:

"Last summer, I had a memorable holiday at the beach. **At first**, I spent many hours swimming and relaxing in the sun. **After that**, I explored the nearby town and tried some traditional dishes, which I really liked. **Also**, I spent quality time with my family, which made me feel very happy and refreshed. **Finally**, we watched a beautiful sunset on the last day."

Band 7

Tips:

- Use complex sentences with good accuracy
- Use a wide range of vocabulary and idiomatic expressions
- Speak fluently with natural intonation
- Provide detailed explanations and reflections

Sample:

"Last summer, I enjoyed a truly memorable holiday at a beautiful seaside town. **Initially**, I spent hours swimming in the crystal-clear water and soaking up the warm sun. **Following that**, I wandered through the charming local markets, sampling authentic dishes like fresh seafood and tropical fruits, which delighted my taste buds. **Moreover**, spending uninterrupted quality time with my family brought me immense joy and strengthened our bonds. **To top it all off**, we ended each day watching stunning sunsets that painted the sky in vibrant colors—an experience I will never forget."

Summary Table

Band	Tips Highlights	Sample Style
5.5	Short, simple, basic ideas	"I go to beach. It was good."
6	Longer, simple linking, basic past tense	"I went to beach. First I swam."
6.5	More variety in grammar & vocabulary	"I spent hours swimming. Also tried local food."
7	Complex sentences, idioms, fluent	"Initially, I spent hours swimming... authentic dishes..."

Sentence Structures (SSS) to Use in Part 2

A. Starting your talk

- "Today, I want to talk about..."
- "I'm going to describe a time when..."
- "One memorable experience I had was..."

B. Sequencing events

- "First of all, I..."
- "After that, I..."
- "Then, I..."
- "Finally, I..."

C. Giving reasons and feelings

- "I enjoyed it because..."
- "It was exciting/fun/relaxing since..."
- "What made it special was..."

D. Adding details

- "For example,..."
- "One thing I particularly liked was..."
- "I also remember that..."

E. Concluding your talk

- "Overall, it was a great experience because..."
- "That's why I will never forget it."
- "I hope to go back there someday."

3. Complex Sentence Structures (Band 6.5 to 7 level)

- **Using relative clauses:**
"The town, **which was very small and quiet**, was perfect for relaxing."
- **Using participle clauses:**
"**Walking along the beach**, I felt completely relaxed."
- **Using conditionals:**
"If I had more time, I would visit more places there."
- **Using connectors for contrast and addition:**
"Although the weather was hot, I enjoyed every minute of my holiday."
"Not only did I swim in the sea, but I also tried local food."

4. Useful Collocations

- Have a memorable experience
- Spend quality time
- Try traditional dishes
- Enjoy the scenery
- Make new friends
- Take lots of photos
- Relax by the beach

Example Part 2 Mini Answer Using These Vocabulary & Structures

"Today, I want to talk about a memorable holiday I had last year. **First of all**, I visited a small seaside town, **which was very peaceful and beautiful**. I spent most of my time swimming in the crystal-clear water and relaxing by the beach. **What made it special was** the chance to try traditional dishes, like fresh seafood, which I had never eaten before. **Walking along the shore**, I felt completely relaxed and happy. **Although** the holiday was short, it was an unforgettable experience. I **hope to go back there someday** to enjoy more of the scenery and local culture."

SENTENCE STRUCTURES FOR IELTS SPEAKING PART 2

A. Starting Your Talk

- "Today, I'm going to talk about..."
- "I'd like to describe a time when..."
- "One experience that I remember well is..."
- "The event/place/person I want to talk about is..."

B. Sequencing Events

- "First of all, I..."
- "Then, I..."
- "After that, I..."
- "Next, I..."
- "Finally, I..."

C. Giving Reasons and Feelings

- "I enjoyed it because..."
- "It was exciting/fun/interesting since..."
- "What made it special was..."
- "I felt really happy/surprised/relaxed when..."
- "The reason I liked it so much is that..."

D. Adding Details

- "For example,..."
- "One thing I particularly liked was..."
- "I also remember that..."
- "Another interesting thing was..."
- "Something I noticed was..."

E. Comparing or Contrasting

- "Although it was..., I still..."
- "Even though it was..., I enjoyed it."
- "On the one hand..., but on the other hand..."
- "While it was..., I preferred..."

F. Using Conditionals

- "If I had more time, I would..."
- "If I had the chance, I would definitely..."
- "If it wasn't for..., I wouldn't have..."

G. Concluding Your Talk

- "Overall, it was a great experience because..."
- "That's why I will never forget it."
- "I hope to do/visit/see it again in the future."
- "In conclusion, it was very memorable and special."